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AI



National security meets next-gen tech at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025's AI Defense panel

TechCrunch Events — 8:00 AM PDT • July 22, 2025

TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 is where breakthrough ideas meet the real-world challenges that define the future — and with over 10,000 startup and VC leaders converging, there's no better place to have the hard conversations. One of the most urgent? How artificial intelligence is reshaping national defense, security, and critical infrastructure in real time.

Enter **AI Defense**, a can't-miss panel discussion taking place on one of the two AI Stages, where leaders from government, venture, and the armed services will explore the high-stakes collision of innovation and national security.

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- The best dating apps aren't even dating apps

Why this conversation matters now

With AI evolving at a blistering pace, the stakes for defense innovation have never been higher. From autonomous systems and decision intelligence to cybersecurity and battlefield readiness, the U.S. defense and intelligence communities are racing to build smarter, more adaptive technologies — without compromising ethics, oversight, or safety.

[This panel](#) explores the delicate balance between intelligence and control, the role of startups in defense innovation, and the multibillion-dollar opportunities emerging at the intersection of national security and AI.

If your startup touches defense, government, cybersecurity, or AI infrastructure, this is a conversation you can't afford to miss.

Where defense, intelligence, and innovation converge

Onstage, you'll hear from [Dr. Kathleen Fisher](#), director of the Information Innovation Office at [DARPA](#), who is leading the charge on tech that gives the U.S. and its allies an edge in the information wars of the 21st century. With a career that spans AT&T Labs and academia at Tufts University, Fisher blends research credibility with strategic vision, and she's shaping the next generation of defense-grade AI.

Joining the panel is [Sri Chandrasekar](#), managing partner at [Point72 Ventures](#), and formerly a leader at In-Q-Tel, the CIA's strategic investment arm. Chandrasekar knows how to spot frontier tech that moves the needle, and he's built investment frameworks to support some of the intelligence community's toughest missions.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

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Rounding out the panel is [Justin Fanelli](#), chief technology officer for the Department of the Navy. Fanelli lives at the intersection of cybersecurity, innovation, and adoption, driving digital transformation across one of the most complex organizations in government. From his DARPA Service Chiefs Fellowship to his nationally recognized work in defense health and command systems, Fanelli brings the boots-on-the-ground perspective to how defense is done in the age of AI.

Catch it live at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

This **AI Defense** panel takes place on the [AI Stage](#). Exact session time coming soon — but don’t wait to claim your pass.

TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 runs October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco. Join 10,000+ startup and VC leaders for three days of conversations and connections that define what’s next. [Grab your pass now before prices increase after July.](#)

Topics: [AI](#) [Disrupt2025](#) [Fundraising](#) [Government&Policy](#) [Security](#) [Startups](#)

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AI



Where AI meets design: Runway co-founder Alejandro Matamala Ortiz takes the AI Stage at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events 3:45 PM PDT · July 10, 2025

[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) is the epicenter where 10,000+ startup and VC leaders gather to explore the future of innovation — and this year, two AI Stages bring the intersection of design and machine learning into sharp focus.

We're thrilled to welcome [Alejandro Matamala Ortiz](#), co-founder and chief design officer at Runway, to one of the AI Stages at Disrupt 2025, taking place October 27-29 in San Francisco. As part of a can't-miss panel conversation, Ortiz will share how design principles are guiding the next generation of generative AI tools — and how his team at [Runway](#) is redefining what creativity looks like in the age of machines.



Why attend this session?

Expect fresh, actionable insights into how creative professionals and technologists can work together to build tools that empower — not replace — human expression. Ortiz will offer a design-first perspective on building intuitive, artist-friendly AI experiences that are already transforming industries, from film to marketing.

Prior to co-founding Runway, Ortiz was a research resident at New York University, where he studied the interaction between artificial intelligence and creativity. Today he leads the company's vision for accessible, cutting-edge creative software that's shaping how the world imagines and produces content.

Join us on one of the [AI Stages and the other five industry stages](#) at Disrupt 2025 to hear from Matamala Ortiz and other leaders who are building the creative engines of tomorrow. [Buy your ticket now and save up to \\$625.](#)

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The votes are in: TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 Audience Choice winners revealed for roundtables and breakouts

TechCrunch Events — 7:30 AM PDT · July 14, 2025

You voted — they made it onto the [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) agenda!

After reviewing hundreds of standout Call for Content submissions and opening the vote to the TechCrunch audience, we've locked in the top five roundtables and top five breakout sessions.

Without further ado, meet the exceptional tech voices — and the sessions they'll lead — that will shape the conversation at Disrupt 2025, taking place

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October 27-29 at San Francisco's Moscone West. [Visit the agenda page](#) for full session and speaker details.

[Grab your ticket now and save up to \\$675 before prices increase.](#)

Breakout session winners

From Vibes to Velocity: How AI Tools Can Help You Achieve Your Development Goals



[Tim Rogers](#)

Staff Product Manager
GitHub Copilot

With vibe coding on the rise, devs are looking to move faster and ship smarter. In this breakout, GitHub PM Tim Rogers dives into Copilot — the AI-powered peer programming tool used by more than 15 million — and how it's reshaping workflows in an autonomous world.

How to Get Acquired in Tech (Without Selling Out): M&A Tips for Founders and Builders



[Aklil Ibssa](#)

Head of Corporate Development and M&A
Coinbase

Coinbase just pulled off crypto's biggest acquisition. In this no-BS session, learn how to make your project irresistible — from product-market fit to community traction — and position for M&A, investment, or partnership without compromising decentralization. If you're an investor, you'll get a cheat sheet for spotting teams building toward high-value outcomes.

AI at the Brink: Strategic Playbook for National Security



[Daniel Hendrycks](#)

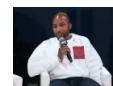
Executive Director
Center for AI Safety (CAIS)

Advanced AI brings risks like bioweapons and cyberattacks amid global competition. This session explores strategic frameworks for AI safety, covering technical checks, non-proliferation, and supply chain security with Dan Hendrycks and key experts.

Latest in Startups

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FUNDRAISING



How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

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 Figma's IPO success is 'a little bit of a meme stock,' says Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

Rebecca Bellan,
Theresa Loconsolo
- 16 hours ago

STARTUPS



Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the 'agent-native economy'

Dominic-Madori Davis
- 16 hours ago



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt,

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Embracing AI for a Better Digital Future



[Matt Madrigal](#)

Chief Technology Officer
Pinterest

AI is at a crossroads, shaping whether it is additive or addictive, inclusive or harmful. Matt shows how Pinterest uses AI for positivity, personalization, and productivity, offering a responsible approach that drives innovation while prioritizing user well-being.

Agentic AI for Startups: Automate, Adapt, and Accelerate Growth



[Anmol Rastogi](#)

Head of Product Management, AI & ML
Amazon Business Amazon

Agentic AI is transforming startups by enabling automation, personalized experiences, and data-driven agility. This session covers identifying AI opportunities, building workflows, and measuring impact using real case studies to help founders accelerate growth and outpace competition.

Roundtable session winners

The Winning Formula: Turning Your Business Into a Trusted, Scalable Community To Drive Growth



[Justine Palefsky](#) and [Tasneem Amina](#)

Co-Founders
Kindred

Join Kindred co-founders Justine Palefsky and Tasneem Amina as they reveal how they transformed home swapping into a community-led movement. Learn their blueprint for building trust, turning members into ambassadors, and driving growth through authentic, values-driven community building.

How to Train Your Model: Taming AI Agents Without Breaking Them



[Kyla Guru](#)
Head of Model Cyber Safety
Anthropic

This interactive session dives into balancing AI safety and usefulness, covering constitutional AI, red-teaming, and steering methods. Attendees will gain frameworks and strategies to build AI models that are both helpful and harmless without losing personality.

Future of Space Economy in the Low Earth Orbit



[Abhi Kumar](#)
Lecturer, Investor, and Advisor
UC Berkeley



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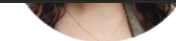
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Explore how Reddit builds AI at scale, balancing relevance, safety, and bias for millions of users. This session tackles community expectations, ethical tradeoffs, and real-world challenges, inviting startups to join a candid discussion on trusted AI development.

AI Evaluation 101: Addressing Challenges to Real-World AI Applications



[Rohit Patel](#)
Director, Meta Superintelligence Labs
Meta

This session breaks down how neural networks generate language and the challenges of deploying GenAI. Learn why evaluation matters and compare

automated, judge-based, and human-rated methods to build tests that measure AI versus human performance for your use case.

Join these sessions — and much more — live at Disrupt 2025

These 10 sessions are just a glimpse of the 250+ speakers and talks at Disrupt. Keep an eye on the [agenda page](#) for new updates, and [grab your ticket now](#) to save up to \$675 before prices rise.

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The new face of defense tech — Ethan Thornton of Mach Industries — takes the AI Stage at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 7:00 AM PDT · August 1, 2025

Autonomous weapons, decentralized strategy, and startup speed — this isn't the future of defense, it's the now. At [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), Ethan Thornton, CEO and founder of Mach Industries, steps onto the [AI Stage](#) to talk about how next-gen defense is being built from the ground up with AI at its core.

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Inside the AI arms race — and the founder aiming to rewrite it

[Ethan Thornton](#) isn't your typical defense industry leader. As the CEO and founder of Mach Industries, he launched the company out of MIT in 2023 with a bold mission: to build decentralized, next-generation defense technologies that can safeguard freedom on a global scale.

Now leading one of the most ambitious startups in the space, Thornton is bringing a fresh perspective to an industry dominated by legacy players. His work blends frontier hardware, software, and autonomy to rethink how nations defend themselves in a rapidly changing world.

From startup lab to battlefield impact

[Mach Industries](#) is part of a new wave of companies proving that AI-native startups can play a critical role in national defense. This session will unpack what that means in practice — from autonomous systems and edge computing to dual-use technologies that blur the lines between commercial innovation and military capability.

Hear from Thornton on navigating funding, regulation, and responsibility at the intersection of tech and geopolitics.

AI isn't just powering chatbots — it's redefining global power

With global tensions rising and investment in defense tech accelerating, this conversation offers an urgent and timely look at how artificial intelligence is reshaping security, strategy, and sovereignty. [Register now to save up to \\$675](#) before prices go up next week, and be in the room with 10,000+ startup and VC leaders shaping the next era of innovation.

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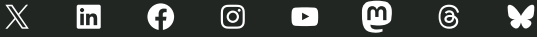
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